

EYEWITNESS November 1968

A Pilot's View

Pilots in Vietnam faced dangers from the ground when flying into a landing zone (LZ) in North Vietnamese territory. Captain Thomas A. Pienta was flying a trail helicopter—tasked with waiting and reporting once the LZ became clear—with his “Rat Pack” gunship platoon when he came under fire from a North Vietnamese unit.

“All hell was breaking loose around us ... because the LZ was filled with 10- to 15-foot-tall baby rubber trees, which were hard to see until I was right on top of them. I had to pick my spot and could not come directly to the ground as I normally did. Snaring a tail rotor in the trees could kill you just as easily as a machine gun.

We were just coming out of translational lift—the point at which a helicopter stops flying and starts hovering—when a rocket-propelled grenade (RPG) slammed into our Huey. It apparently hit in the left fuel cell just above Brady's gun well. I believe he died instantly. PFC Hoppe, on the right door gun, was blown out of the ship.

We were completely engulfed in flames. The JP-4 fuel and magnesium combined to make a lethal fire. The cliché about not hearing the one that gets you was true in my case. I first thought that a fragmentation grenade had inadvertently been dropped in our ship ... It seemed as if there was a big whoosh, similar to the effect a Zippo lighter has after being freshly overfilled and lit, or the whoosh of a propane grill lighting after the gas has been left on too long before the igniter is applied. All the oxygen in the Huey was immediately sucked up by the flames, and we were on fire.”

CAPTAIN THOMAS A. PIENTA DESCRIBING HIS EXPERIENCE AS A HELICOPTER PILOT TO *VIETNAM* MAGAZINE, DECEMBER 1996